Guitar Exercises - Section XII, Level 86

Funk and R&B; Groove Vocabulary

Sixteenth Muting • Chord Stabs • Ghost Hierarchy • Syncopated Triads • Bass-Space Discipline

Level 86 of the fixed 105-level core curriculum. HARD STOP after Level 105.

Level 85 established pocket as control of duration, muting, attack placement, and rhythm-section relationship. Level 86 narrows the focus to funk and R&B;, where note length and empty space often matter as much as pitch.

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J	Pocket recovery and performance audit	64
	TOTAL	1504

Core rule: ghosts support the groove; pitched stabs define it. Do not let muted contacts become louder than the chord.

Reference - Sixteenth-Note Contact Hierarchy

Maintain continuous D-U-D-U motion through every sixteenth slot. P = pitched chord, g = soft ghost contact, x = stronger muted accent, - = air stroke, ~ = sustain.

Level	Symbol	Job
1	P	structural pitched attack
2	x	strong percussive mute / backbeat accent
3	g	quiet ghost motion that supports subdivision
4	-	air stroke; motion only
5	~	sustain; no new attack

Practice order: clap accents -> muted strings -> one triad -> full groove. The hierarchy must remain audible at low volume.

Module A - Ghost-Note Hierarchy

Cell	1 e & a | 2 e & a | 3 e & a | 4 e & a	Goal
1	P g g g | P g g g | P g g g | P g g g	one pitched contact per beat
2	P g x g | P g x g | P g x g | P g x g	accent the &
3	g P g x | g P g x | g P g x | g P g x	late chord stab
4	P x g g | g x P g | P x g g | g x P g	asymmetrical hierarchy
5	P g g x | g P x g | P g g x | g P x g	backbeat-oriented ghosts
6	g g P g | x g g P | g g P g | x g g P	sparse syncopation

Pass 1: all contacts muted. Pass 2: replace P with Am7 or D9 triads. Pass 3: lower every g until it is felt more than heard.

Module B - Chord-Stab Duration

Use the same attack time but vary how long the chord survives.

Duration	Exercise	Release cue
Long	P~~~	hold through full beat
Half-beat	P~--	release at &
Quarter-beat	P---	release before e
Stab + ghost	Pg--	pitch then immediate muted motion
Late stab	---P	attack on a
Tie into next beat	---P | ~---	do not re-attack beat 1

Apply to Am7, D9, G13, Cmaj9, F#m7, and E9. The left hand controls length; the right hand does not slow down.

Module C - Syncopated Triads and Shells

Cell	Harmony	Contact points
1	Am7	1, a2, &3, a4
2	D9	&1, 2, a3, &4
3	G13	a1, &2, 4
4	Cmaj9	1, &2, a3
5	F#m7	&1, a2, &4
6	E9	2, a2, &3, 4
7	Am7 -> D9	1 / a2 / &4 change
8	Cmaj7 -> Dm7 -> G7	one triad stab per beat, then displace by one sixteenth

Use three-note triads first. Full chord grips are optional and should not increase noise or reduce release control.

Module D - Bass-Space Discipline

The guitar must leave intentional holes for bass landmarks.

Bass event	Guitar rule
Root on beat 1	do not attack full chord on beat 1; answer on &1 or beat 2
Octave hit on &2	rest or ghost at &2
Fill on beat 4	end guitar phrase by beat 3&
Syncopated 1-a-2&	use sustained upper chord, not matching rhythm
Walking quarters	one short upper chord per half-bar
Bass rests	guitar may briefly increase density

Record or loop each bass figure. Then add the guitar part without duplicating the bass rhythm unless the exercise explicitly asks for a unison hit.

Module E - One-Chord Funk Pocket Variations

Name	Chord	Pattern	Purpose
Pocket 1	Am7	P g x g | g P g x | P g x g | g P g x	tight 16th-grid funk
Pocket 2	D9	g g P g | x g g P | g g P g | x g g P	offbeat stabs
Pocket 3	E9	P--- | --Pg | P--- | g-Pg	space-heavy
Pocket 4	G13	P g g x | --P- | g x g P | ----	backbeat contrast
Pocket 5	Am7	P~-- | g-P- | --xg | P---	mixed length
Pocket 6	D9	--P- | g-xg | P--- | --P-	late sixteenth emphasis
Pocket 7	E9	Pggg | xggP | gPxg | P---	dense but hierarchical
Pocket 8	Am7	P--- | ---- | --P- | ----	extreme space

Run all eight cells at one tempo. The musical difference must come from contact hierarchy and duration, not tempo change.

Module F - R&B; Pocket Variations

Study	Harmony	Primary behavior
Slow R&B	Cmaj7-Am7	1 and 3 bass-side; upper shell on &2 and &4
Neo-soul pocket	Am9-D9	short upper voicings; hammer-on embellishment after the stab
Soul backbeat	Cmaj7-Dm7-G7-Cmaj7	shell on 2 and 4, melodic answer in remaining space
Two-chord vamp	F#m7-B7	pedal top note; syncopated inner movement
Ballad pulse	Am7-Fmaj7	long beat-1 chord, short beat-3 answer
Gospel/R&B turn	Cmaj7-A7-Dm7-G7	voice-led shells; chromatic bass approach
High-register comp	Em7-A7	triads only; bass register left empty
Sparse turnaround	Dm7-G7-Cmaj7	one chord hit, one melodic answer per bar

Do not turn the embellishment into a continuous lick. The chord stab remains the structural event.

Module G - Register, Inversion, and Texture Rotation

Pass	Voicing / register	Instruction
1	low partial chord	short attacks, leave high register empty
2	middle shell	same rhythm, narrower attack zone
3	high triad	same rhythm, more space below
4	drop-2 voicing	same contacts, longer sustain
5	bass note + upper triad	split role between low and high voices
6	melodic fragment only	remove chord body but preserve groove landmarks

Use the same four-bar Am7-D9-G13-Cmaj9 progression for all passes. The groove must survive the register change.

Module H - Study 1 - Tight funk

| Am7 | D9 | Am7 | E9 | Am7 | D9 | E9 | Am7 |

Sixteenth ghost grid; short triads; no full chord on bass fill in bar 4.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/ghost grid only
2	muted strings
3	triads/shells
4	full pocket
5	add one bass-space decision per bar
6	record with click only on 2 and 4

Module H - Study 2 - Neo-soul/R&B;

| Cmaj9 | Am9 | Dm9 | G13 | Em7 | A7 | Dm9 | G13 |

Longer voicings, inner-voice embellishment after the attack, sparse answers.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/ghost grid only
2	muted strings
3	triads/shells
4	full pocket
5	add one bass-space decision per bar
6	record with click only on 2 and 4

Module H - Study 3 - Backbeat soul

| Cmaj7 | Fmaj7 | Dm7 | G7 | Em7 | A7 | Dm7 | G7 |

Shells on 2 and 4; melody fills only after the backbeat releases.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/ghost grid only
2	muted strings
3	triads/shells
4	full pocket
5	add one bass-space decision per bar
6	record with click only on 2 and 4

Module H - Study 4 - Bass-space vamp

| F#m7 | B7 | F#m7 | B7 | Emaj7 | C#m7 | F#m7 | B7 |

Bass supplies syncopation; guitar uses sustained upper voicings and occasional short stabs.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/ghost grid only
2	muted strings
3	triads/shells
4	full pocket
5	add one bass-space decision per bar
6	record with click only on 2 and 4

Module I - Thirty-Two-Bar Funk/R&B; Capstone

Bars	Harmony	Feel	Voicing	Dynamic
1-4	Am7-D9-Am7-E9	tight funk	short triads	mp
5-8	Cmaj9-Am9-Dm9-G13	neo-soul/R&B	upper extensions	mf
9-12	Cmaj7-Fmaj7-Dm7-G7	backbeat soul	shells	mf
13-16	F#m7-B7-F#m7-B7	bass-space vamp	sustain	mp
17-20	Am7-D9-Am7-E9	dense ghost hierarchy	triads	f
21-24	Cmaj9-Am9-Dm9-G13	sparse R&B	drop-2	mp
25-28	Em7-A7-Dm7-G7	syncopated turnaround	upper triads	mf
29-32	Cmaj7-A7-Dm7-G7	release/ending	shell -> sustain	f -> p

Passes: muted groove -> harmony -> bass-space choices -> register orchestration -> one uninterrupted recorded take. The tempo never changes between sections.

Module J - Pocket Recovery and Audit

Failure	Immediate repair
Ghosts too loud	mute strings and exaggerate P>x>g hierarchy
Stabs ring	practice left-hand release without changing attack time
Groove rushes	foot quarter notes; halve pitched density
Bass/guitar collide	delete guitar attack at bass landmark
R&B fill becomes lick	limit answer to 2-3 notes
Register change breaks pocket	one bar muted grid before new voicing
Syncopation feels random	speak sixteenth count and mark P contacts
Form lost	one shell on beat 1 until next 4-bar boundary

Mastery: 14/16 or better on two separate days across pulse, ghost hierarchy, note length, chord-stab accuracy, bass-space discipline, register control, groove contrast, and recovery. No zero in pulse, ghost hierarchy, bass-space discipline, or recovery.

NEXT: Level 87 develops reggae/ska, soul, disco, and Motown-style groove principles - offbeat placement, clipped chord duration, repeated rhythm figures, octave/bass interaction, and section-specific texture.